

■ By Subhash Mishra

The slogans painted on the walls and roadside stalls in Katarniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary in eastern Uttar Pradesh tell a tragic story. "The forest is yours, not the Government's," is the defiant message put up by local groups who have unleashed a war on forest officials and, more crucially, on the forests. The protected forests in this area are a major source of what is known as "green gold," the valuable timber of saal, sheesham and khair trees. Inevitably, they, along with the animals who shelter in their shade, have become prime targets for the ever-ravenous forest mafia.

That's not all. The forest reserve is also under threat from gangs of land sharks with the result that the state's wildlife conservation efforts have come under unprecedented pressure. For example, the Uttar Pradesh Forest Department has lost control over nearly 288 sq km of the reserve. This area, worth around Rs 2,663 crore, is now in the illegal possession of the so-called forest mafia acting in concert with powerful land sharks who have encroached deep into the forests. The predictable and tragic result is that felling of valuable trees and poaching of wild animals, including endangered species like the tiger, have increased at an alarming rate.

For the mafia, the forests of Uttar Pradesh are a prize target. The Terai, Vindhya and Bundelkhand regions of the state are rich in "green gold", while mineral resources dot the Bundelkhand and Vindhya regions. In view of the growing population, unemployment and escalating prices of timber and wildlife products in international markets, forests in the state have turned into sanctuaries for smugglers and mafia. Last December, Special Task Force officials caught four smugglers red-handed with three tiger and three leopard skins in their possession.

Such arrests, however, are rare. The gangs are well-organised and armed with lethal weapons, modern communication systems and fast vehicles. For forest department officials, it's an unequal war. Barely 14,000 officials manage 21,833 sq km of forests with half of them being deployed in the field for conservation work and the other

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GROWING THREAT:
Smugglers caught in
Allahabad by the STF

half employed as office staff. Some range officers, who are supposed to be at the spearhead of the forest management system, have not been promoted for 27 years. Also, the state government has not been able to fulfil its promise of providing faster vehicles, modern communication gadgets and more effective firearms, including AK-47s, for patrol and anti-poaching operations. Forest guards currently battle the mafia and poachers with outdated 12-bore guns. "I have no qualms in admitting that we are fighting the mafia with our hands tied," says Pinaki Prasad Singh, deputy director of the Dudhwa National Park, one of the

state's best known reserves. "We have been demanding promotions, better communication systems and weaponry but the government has failed to meet these demands. It reflects the total lack of seriousness of the state government in wildlife conservation and forest management," says Gopal Ojha, president of the Uttar Pradesh Regional Forest Officers' Association.

Singh also laments the discriminatory attitude of the government towards forest officials who risk their lives in dealing with mafia. "If police officers kill one dacoit, they are given awards by the President of India and also by the state. What have we got for